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ELECTION 2026
ILLINOIS GOVERNOR

Bailey holds firm in attack on crime law

Republican candidate wants repeal of reform, though Chicago violent crime stats show drop

By **Jeremy Gorner**
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Four years after he called Chicago a “hellhole” and lost the race for governor by nearly 13 percentage points, Darren Bailey’s attempt at running a different kind of campaign has included declaring he’s ready to “stop some of the political rhetoric that I’ve been a part of” and trying to avoid being portrayed as a MAGA Republican amid President Donald Trump’s unpopularity in Illinois.

While the GOP nominee in his second bid for governor has tried a different marketing tack even as he holds many of the same positions and is endorsed by Trump, one issue has remained consistent in principle and publicity — Bailey still wants to repeal the SAFE-T Act, the sweeping and controversial 2021 criminal justice overhaul that abolished cash bail in Illinois.

Bailey says he doesn’t object to the law’s effort of keeping people charged with crimes from sitting in jail simply because they can’t afford bail. But he argues it has gone far beyond that.

“It turned into now just anybody who commits almost any crime is free to walk,” Bailey said in April after a gun rights event in Springfield, in a clear overstatement.

Indeed, Bailey’s case against the law has rested on some exaggeration and anecdotes that broader data don’t always support. Chicago has seen steep declines in homicides and shootings in recent years. Cook County court data show the vast majority of defendants released while awaiting trial are not charged with new violent crimes, and the county jail now holds more people than it did before cash bail ended. Even some Republicans familiar with the law, including DuPage County’s top prosecutor, say it should be fixed, not repealed.

Still, Bailey is sticking with the message, betting that crime, long a potent issue for Republicans, and the SAFE-T Act in particular remain vulnerabilities for Gov. JB Pritzker and a Democratic Party that controls every statewide office and

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President Donald Trump presents the Presidents Cup trophy to USA team captain Brandt Snedeker after the U.S. won the 2026 Presidents Cup at Medinah Country Club on Sunday in Medinah. **ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE PHOTOS**

At Medinah, Trump gets mostly warm reception

Crowd cheers president in visit to golf tournament as dozens protest outside event

By **Olivia Olander**
CHICAGO TRIBUNE
and **Steve Zalusky**
DAILY HERALD

President Donald Trump delivered very brief opening remarks and stuck around until the closing ceremony at the Presidents Cup on Sunday, speaking to a crowd of thousands — many in patriotic gear — at Medinah Country Club as protesters gathered far out of sight.

“These people want to see golf. They don’t want to hear speeches,” Trump said during morning remarks that lasted less than three minutes. “I’ll only say this: Our country is doing great, better than ever before.”

It was Trump’s first public appearance in the Chicago area since he won the 2024 presidential election, and it came a year after the period when his administration surged aggressive immigration enforcement to Chicago in Operation Midway Blitz.



Trump supporters and protesters argue outside the Presidents Cup. **E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Trump reserved the beginning of his short speech for “the fake news media,” whom he said would report that he was received badly.

He also noted that some of the best players in the world were expected to play and predicted “a very interesting day of golf.”

As players teed off, the president stayed to watch them for close to two hours, standing near where they came onto the course and greeting a few. He disappeared from sight for several hours but then returned for the awards ceremony. The Interna-

tional team finished strong Saturday, but the U.S. stormed back Sunday to win the cup.

Before fans’ eyes were on the U.S. and International teams, the eyes of the world were on Trump last week, as he welcomed Chinese President Xi Jinping to Washington and told the United Nations General Assembly that he may “annihilate” Iran if a deal isn’t reached to end the months-long war he started alongside Israel.

This weekend, the president turned his attention to more recreational affairs, attending Tennessee’s college football game against Texas on Saturday before flying to the Chicago area Sunday morning. More than 30,000 spectators were expected daily during Presidents Cup tournament play Thursday through Sunday, the Daily Herald previously reported.

Trump has made several remarks showing disdain for Chicago over the years, perhaps

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Riding to the rescue of retired racehorses

When Hawthorne Race Course shut down, programs like Galloping Out were there to help

By **Robert McCoppin**
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Horse racing makes Heidi Sheridan nervous, worrying whether the animals will get hurt. But now Sheridan is taking lessons and learning to ride a former racing thoroughbred, not for business, but for pleasure.

“I never in a million years thought I would own a horse,” Sheridan said. “My husband wasn’t a big fan, but he showed up in my driveway with a ‘96 Mustang, so I said, ‘I’m going to get my own horse.’”

As she spoke, her horse, Finley, a bay-colored gelding that won more than \$50,000 in his racing year at tracks including the former Arling-



Avery Kucan gets Maggie, a former racehorse, ready for training on Thursday at Tukaway Farm in Hampshire. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

ton Park and Churchill Downs, caught her under the chin with his muzzle, making her smile as she leaned out of the way.

Sheridan, a school social worker, bought Finley through Gallop-

ing Out, a program that retrains retired racehorses for new lives and careers. The recent closing of Hawthorne Race Course brought a surge in the number of surplus thoroughbreds. But programs like

Galloping Out have been working for years to save them.

The Illinois Thoroughbred Horsemen’s Association created

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INSIDE

Slow storm lashes, floods East Coast

Coastal residents in the Northeast slogged through floodwaters for a second day as a nor’easter pummeled the shoreline, knocking out power to tens of thousands of homes. **Nation & World**

Pope condemns assisted dying

Pope Leo XIV condemned the legalization of medically assisted death as immoral “false compassion,” reaffirming Catholic teaching on the sanctity of life during a visit to France. **Nation & World**

Bears turn to QB Keenum to start

Quarterback Tyson Bagent is out of concussion protocol, but the Chicago Bears will turn to Case Keenum to start Monday night’s game against the Philadelphia Eagles at Soldier Field. **Sports**

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